

Holding Fast

Least-successful, long-serving, always controversial



VIJAY KUMAR MALHOTRA
Archery Association of India
President—37 years



K.P. SINGH DEO
Rowing Federation of India
President—26 years



LALIT BHANOT
Athletics Federation of India
Secretary General—
22 years



JAGDISH TYTLER
Judo Federation of India
President—20 years



S.S. DHINDSA
Cycling Federation of India
President—15 years



V.K. VERMA
Badminton Association of India
President—12 years



B.S. ADITYAN
Volleyball Federation of India
President—12 years



ABHAY SINGH CHAUTALA
Indian Amateur Boxing
Federation
President—10 years



AJAY CHAUTALA
Table Tennis Federation of India
President—10 years



DIG VIJAY SINGH
National Rifle
Association of India
President—10 years



YASHWANT SINHA
All India Tennis Association
President—10 years



BIRENDRA P. BAISHYA
Indian Weightlifting Federation
A new boss for the body
banned twice for doping

Resource Development (Department of Sports and Youth Affairs), the Sports Authority of India (SAI), the Netaji Subhash National Institute of Sports and IOA and federations of key sports like athletics, badminton, boxing, chess, football, hockey, shooting, tennis and weightlifting.

The case is being heard by the Delhi High Court Division Bench No.1 with acting chief justices Madan B. Lokur and Mukta Gupta and all the lawyers hauled in are sweating.

The case is up next in court on April 19, during which the Sports Ministry has a weighty to-do list: to file an affidavit of their response, review of the electoral colleges structure of all sports federations, find minutes of several meetings and a report by a Core Group formed in 2001, after the 1975 order about tenure was put on hold.

Regardless of what the meeting with the IOC is like or what happens to Gill in the political hurly burly, the federations will next be questioned about their electorates. The 1975 regulation said 25 per cent of every Federation's voting bank had to include the sport's eminent athletes; in real teams the numbers barely add up to five per cent.

Gill is confident that he will be able to follow through by persistence alone. Yet, it is not as if the ministry's own practices are flawless. SAI is expected to nurture talent and support federations in training and coaching is a bureaucratic labyrinth. Where tenders are invited for athletic equipment and then awarded to the lowest bidder as if it were sand being purchased. Bad practice is how a Rs 50-crore full bore rifle range is already set up but shooters have had to borrow rifles to practice. In any case, the range will be of no use after the 2010 Games as the event is not found in other international events.

Bindra says, "Elsewhere the athlete is the No.1 priority, the No.1 stakeholder in sport. In India, it is like most athletes do not exist." This overall systems failure, thanks to federations and government alike, has led to a poisonous mutation of Indian sports. It is why five months before the 2010 Games, the spotlight is not on our athletes, but our squabbling administrators. ■

High Court ruled that the BCCI was a private body that performed public functions and was, therefore, accountable to the public. After a two-year break in which he did his day job of litigation in civil and criminal cases and setting up a sports law firm, Mehra put his mind to this wider universe in 2006. His PIL has reached a point where even

the ministry has been pushed to indicate its intent to improve.

By the time he finished his research, Mehra's PIL was 150 pages long with as many as 73 National Sports Federations being questioned.

Its respondents are now just 13 who are topped up by the Union of India through the Ministry of Human